

Supper Spiritual Communion

doc-supper-spiritual-communion

Sacraments · Lord's Supper · doctrine · divided_lineages

DISPUTED

Supported across many Bible texts
Subject named directly in Scripture
No NT manuscript apparatus applies

Statement under examination

The Lord's Supper includes spiritual communion with the risen Christ by faith; believers feed on Christ spiritually, distinguishing the position from bare Zwinglian memorialism.

In plain language

The plain wording of these passages supports a real sharing in Christ at the Lord's table, not just a mental memory. In 1 Corinthians 10:16 Paul calls the cup the 'participation' or 'fellowship' (koinonia) of the blood of Christ and the broken bread the 'participation' (koinonia) of the body of Christ. The grammar makes the cup and bread a participation in what they signify, and the very next verses press the point: all of us 'partake' or 'share in' (metecho) of the one loaf, and those who eat sacrifices are 'fellow partakers' (koinonos) of the altar, just as pagans who eat at idol feasts become partakers with demons. Because you cannot share both the Lord's table and the demons' table, the sharing is real and has consequences, which rules out a bare recollection. The John 6 discourse uses ordinary eating verbs and the vivid present-tense word 'to eat' or 'gnaw' (trogo), meaning to keep eating or feeding, and says the one who eats and drinks has eternal life and 'abides' (meno) in Christ while Christ abides in him. That reaches past simple remembering toward a living union. Here, though, the words hit their limit. The same word 'participation' or 'fellowship' (koinonia) is used elsewhere, in 1 John 1:3, to mean fellowship WITH the Father and the Son, that is, a relationship between persons, while in 1 Corinthians 10:16 it is participation IN a thing, the blood and body. One word carries both lanes, and the grammar does not rank them. On top of that, John 6:63 says 'the Spirit' (pneuma) gives life and 'the flesh' (sarx) profits nothing, but the word for 'flesh' (sarx) there can mean either Christ's flesh, ruling out a bodily eating, or the merely natural way of understanding, ruling out only a crude literal chewing. Because the vocabulary secures participation but leaves the exact manner open, careful readers reach a feeding-by-the-Spirit view, a remembrance-and-fellowship view, or a bodily-reception view from the same words. For that reason the verdict is recorded as disputed.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0227	ἀληθής	alēthēs	true	
G0230	ἀληθώς	alēthōs	truly	
G0740	ἄρτος	artos	bread	99
G1035	βρῶσις	brōsis	eating	
G2198	ζάω	zaō	to live	
G2222	ζωή	zoe	life	136
G2842	κοινωνία	koinonia	participation	19
G2844	κοινωνός	koinonos	participant	10

G3306	μένω	meno	to stay	118
G3348	μετέχω	metecho	to share	8
G4095	πίνω	pino	to drink	75
G4151	πνεῦμα	pneuma	spirit/breath	379
G4561	σάρξ	sarx	flesh	152
G4983	σῶμα	soma	body	144
G5176	τρώγω	trogo	to eat	6
G5315	ἐσθίω	esthio	to eat	97

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

The lexicon firmly establishes a real participation in the body and blood of Christ at the Supper, but it does not by itself fix the MODE of that participation, which is what the stem specifies. In 1 Corinthians 10:16 the word for participation, sharing, or fellowship (koinonia, G2842) stands twice as a predicate nominative (a noun completing a 'X is Y' statement) with the linking verb 'is' (estin), governing an objective genitive (a participation 'of the blood, of the body of Christ'), and the negative interrogative particles (ouchi, G3780) expect a 'yes' answer. Verses 17 to 21 reinforce this with the verb 'to partake' or 'share in' (metecho, G3348, 'we all partake') and the noun 'fellow partaker' or 'sharer' (koinonos, G2844, 'fellow partakers of the altar, of demons'), so the sharing is objective and exclusive, which excludes a bare recollection model. John 6 pairs the common eating verb 'to eat' (phago) and 'to eat' or 'gnaw' (trogo, G5176, a vivid eating verb, only six occurrences, two of them ordinary meals in Matthew 24:38 and John 13:18) with 'to abide' or 'remain' (meno, mutual indwelling). The disputed point is that 'participation' or 'fellowship' (koinonia) is canonically polysemous (carries more than one sense across the canon): with the preposition 'with' (meta) plus a person it means interpersonal fellowship (1 John 1:3), with a genitive of thing (a noun in the 'of-X' grammatical form) it means participation in that thing, and John 6:63 ('the Spirit gives life, the flesh profits nothing') is grammatically ambiguous as to whether 'flesh' (sarx, G4561) denotes Christ's flesh or merely the carnal mode of understanding. The words secure participation but leave 'spiritual', 'by faith', and 'risen' underdetermined, so the proposition is materially contested.

Scripture

1Cor.10.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2842 κοινωνία, G4983 σῶμα

Reasoning. The cup is named the 'participation, sharing, or fellowship' (koinonia) of the blood of Christ and the broken bread the 'participation' (koinonia) of the body of Christ. In the morphology 'participation' (koinonia) stands twice as nominative singular feminine (a noun in the subject grammatical form) predicate nominative (a noun completing a 'X is Y' statement) with the linking verb 'is' (estin, present indicative, an ongoing, simple statement of fact), governing an objective genitive (a noun in the 'of-X' grammatical form pointing to the object of the action), so 'of the blood, of the body' means the elements ARE a participation in what they signify. The two negative interrogative particles 'is it not?' (ouchi, G3780) expect an emphatic 'yes'. The noun establishes real participation, not bare recollection, but by itself it does not specify the mode of that participation.

1Cor.10.17 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0740 ἄρτος, G3348 μετέχω

Reasoning. Because there is one bread, the many are one body, for all 'partake' or 'share in' (metechomen, from metecho, G3348, present active indicative first plural, an ongoing, simple statement of fact in the 'we' form) of the one bread. The verb 'to partake' or 'share in' (metecho) means to share in or take part in, and here it ties the act to corporate union with Christ and with one another, framing the meal as a sharing IN rather than a mere memorial OF.

1Cor.10.18 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2844 κοινωνός, G5315 ἐσθίω

Reasoning. Those 'eating' (esthiontes, from esthio, the common verb for eating) the sacrifices are 'fellow partakers' or 'sharers' (koinonoi, plural of koinonos, G2844) of the altar. Paul argues by direct analogy: the altar eaters share objectively in the altar, just as in 1 Corinthians 10:20 to 21 the pagans become 'fellow partakers' (koinonoi) of demons and cannot also 'partake' (metechein, infinitive of metecho, meaning 'to share in') of the Lord's table. This parallel shows the 'participation' (koinonia) of 1 Corinthians 10:16 is real and consequential participation, which forecloses a purely commemorative reading, though it still does not fix the participation as spiritual, bodily, or merely communal.

John.6.54 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G5176 τρώγω, G2222 ζωή

Reasoning. The one 'eating' or 'gnawing' (trogo, G5176, present active participle, the ongoing 'one who is eating' form, durative aspect meaning continuing action) my flesh and drinking my blood has 'eternal life' (zoe, G2222, life) and will be raised at the last day. The present participle marks ongoing action and the result clause ties the eating to possession of eternal life. The verb 'to eat' or 'gnaw' (trogo) is concrete, but it carries no technical sacramental sense: of its six canonical occurrences two are ordinary eating (Matthew 24:38, John 13:18), and John 6:53 uses the common verb 'to eat' (phago) for the same act, so the verb signals durative (ongoing) eating, not a particular physical mode.

John.6.56 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G5176 τρώγω, G3306 μένω

Reasoning. The one 'eating' (trogo) my flesh and drinking my blood 'abides' or 'remains' (menei, from meno, G3306, present active indicative, an ongoing, simple statement of fact) in me and I in him. The reciprocal 'in me, and I in him' (en emoi, kago en auto) formula makes the eating a means of mutual abiding union, language that elsewhere in John (14:20, 15:4) and 1 John (3:24) marks Spirit-wrought indwelling, which supports a participatory rather than a purely commemorative construal.

John.6.57 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G5176 τρώγω, G2198 ζάω

Reasoning. Just as the living Father sent me and I 'live' (zo, from zao, G2198, the verb to live) because of the Father, so the one 'eating' (trogo) me will 'live' (zesei, future tense of zao) because of me. The grammar builds a chain of living relation, Father to Son to eater, with the preposition 'because of' or 'through' (dia) plus the accusative (a noun in the direct-object grammatical form) marking the ground of life. The life flows by a personal, relational dependence, which fits an animating union but does not by itself specify the physical mode of the eating.

John.6.63 · complicates · genre: gospel

Key terms. G4151 πνεῦμα, G4561 σὰρξ

Reasoning. 'The Spirit is the one giving life' (to pneuma estin to zoopoion, where pneuma G4151 is 'Spirit' and the participle means 'making alive'), 'the flesh profits nothing' (he sarx ouk ophelai ouden, where sarx G4561 is 'flesh'), 'the words I have spoken to you are spirit and they are life.' This is the load-bearing disambiguator (the verse that decides the meaning) and it is genuinely ambiguous in the grammar: 'the flesh' (he sarx) is the same noun (G4561) used for 'my flesh' in John 6:51 to 56, so it can be read as ruling out a fleshly mode of eating entirely, OR as the principle of merely natural, carnal apprehension, in which case it rules out only a crassly literal flesh-eating. The lexicon alone cannot decide which referent 'flesh' (sarx) carries here.

1John.1.3 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2842 κοινωνία

Reasoning. 'Fellowship' or 'participation' (koinonia) here is construed with the preposition 'with' (meta) plus persons: 'fellowship WITH us', and 'our fellowship is WITH the Father and WITH the Son Jesus Christ'. This is the strongest interpersonal-relational sense of the same noun used in 1 Corinthians 10:16, and the grammatical contrast is decisive for the dispute: 'fellowship' (koinonia) plus 'with' (meta) plus a person denotes fellowship with that person, while 'participation' (koinonia) plus a genitive of thing (a noun in the 'of-X' grammatical form, as in 1 Corinthians 10:16) denotes participation in that thing. The one word carries both lanes, which is why readers diverge.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
1Cor.10.16	Matt.26.26	openbible	17
1Cor.10.16	Acts.2.42	openbible	12
1Cor.10.16	1Cor.11.23	openbible	12
1Cor.10.16	1John.1.3	openbible	7
1Cor.10.16	1Cor.10.20	tsk	1
1Cor.10.16	1Cor.10.21	tsk	1
John.6.56	1John.3.24	openbible	14
John.6.56	John.15.4	openbible	12
John.6.56	John.14.20	tsk	1
John.6.63	Gal.5.25	openbible	60
John.6.63	Heb.4.12	openbible	60
John.6.63	John.6.68	tsk	1
John.6.54	John.6.27	tsk	1

Complicating texts

John.6.63 · addressed

The clause 'the flesh profits nothing', with 'the Spirit' (pneuma) as the life-giver and 'the words' named 'spirit and life', blocks a crassly literal flesh-eating reading and points reception toward the Spirit and the word. But the referent of 'the flesh' (he sarx) is grammatically open: it is the same noun used for Christ's flesh earlier in the discourse, so it can negate a fleshly mode altogether or only a carnal mode of understanding. The lexicon does not adjudicate between a spiritual-feeding-by-faith model and other participatory models, which is why the verdict is disputed rather than affirmed.

John.6.58 · addressed

The manna contrast ('the fathers ate and died, the one eating this bread lives forever') frames the eating eschatologically (in terms of the last things) and christologically (in terms of who Christ is) rather than as a bare ritual recollection, supporting genuine participation. It does not specify whether the participation is the Supper rite specifically or faith-union with Christ broadly, so it neither confirms nor denies the precise stem qualifiers.

1John.1.3 · addressed

This verse displays 'fellowship' (koinonia) in its strongest interpersonal sense (fellowship with the Father and the Son, with the preposition 'with' (meta) plus a person), which legitimately supplies the memorial and communal lens a canonical reading in which 'participation' (koinonia) in 1 Corinthians 10:16 could lean toward fellowship rather than participation in a substance. It is unresolved at the lexical level because the genitive construction (the 'of-X' grammatical form) in 1 Corinthians 10:16 differs grammatically from the 'with' (meta) construction here, so the canon supplies two attested syntaxes of the same word that the bare vocabulary does not rank.

Concordance traversed

G2842, G2844, G3348, G5176, G5315, G4095, G4561, G2222, G4983, G0740, G3306, G4151, G1035, G0227, G0230

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

Jhn6.55-alethes-alethos at John.6.55: impact none. The critical text reads 'true' (alethes, G0227, adjective, 'my flesh is TRUE food, true drink') while TR and Byz (the Textus Receptus and Byzantine majority text traditions) read 'truly' (alethos, G0230, adverb, 'truly food'). This is recorded in the TAGNT (Translators Amalgamated Greek New Testament) meaning_variants for both occurrences. The choice shifts emphasis slightly but does not touch the participation vocabulary ('participation' koinonia, 'eating' trogo, 'abiding' meno), so the verdict is unaffected.

All anchor verses fall in John 6 and 1 Corinthians 10, outside the ingested CBGM (Coherence-Based Genealogical Method) 3 John sample, and a direct query for VariantUnit nodes on these refs returned none, so the status 'not in ECM scope' (ECM apparatus is the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) holds. The only attested variant on the anchors is the John 6:55 'true' (alethes) versus 'truly' (alethos) reading, which is immaterial to the participation question. The verdict is variant robust.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. spiritual_presence, memorialism, corporeal_real_presence

analogia scripturae invoked

spiritual_presence: affirms · Takes 'participation' (koinonia) plus genitive (the 'of-X' grammatical form) in 1 Corinthians 10:16 as real participation in the blood and body, reads the abiding union of John 6:56 as Spirit-wrought, and reads John 6:63 as locating that participation in the Spirit and the word. On this reading the believer truly feeds on the risen Christ by faith, so the act is genuinely more than memory yet not a bodily ingestion.

memorialism: complicates · Notes that 'fellowship' (koinonia) elsewhere (1 John 1:3, with the preposition 'with' (meta) plus a person) means interpersonal fellowship and that 1 Corinthians 10:17 stresses the many being one body, so reads the cup and bread as a shared covenant sign that joins believers to Christ and one another by remembrance and faith. It reads John 6:63 ('the flesh profits nothing') and the pre-institution discourse setting as making the eating a figure for believing, so it denies that the words require participation in any substance.

corporeal_real_presence: complicates · Takes the objective genitive 'participation' (koinonia) of the body, the concrete present participle 'eating' or 'gnawing' (trogo), the warning of unworthy eating elsewhere, and the parallel with literal altar sacrifices in 1 Corinthians 10:18 to 21 as pointing to a bodily reception of Christ in the elements that exceeds the qualifier 'spiritual'. It affirms real participation but contests 'by faith' and 'spiritual' as too thin to capture what the vocabulary of eating and the body allows.

The lexical data anchors genuine participation ('participation' koinonia, 'fellow partaker' koinonos, 'partake' metecho, 'eating' trogo, 'abide' meno) and the altar analogy in 1 Corinthians 10:18 to 21 forecloses pure recollection. But the precise stem qualifiers ('spiritual', 'risen', 'by faith', 'not bare memorialism') sit exactly where three frameworks diverge, because 'participation' or 'fellowship' (koinonia) is canonically polysemous (carries more than one sense across the canon: participation in a thing versus fellowship with a person) and the referent of 'flesh' (sarx) in John 6:63 is grammatically open. The 'analogy of Scripture' (analogia scripturae, the practice of letting Scripture interpret Scripture) therefore yields a contested rather than a single reading.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. The Lord's Supper involves the participant's sharing in the body and blood of Christ; describe what manner of participation, if any, the New Testament vocabulary specifies.

The stem is verdict-preloaded in two ways. First, distinguishing the position from bare Zwinglian memorialism names a tradition-specific category and sets up the desired contrast in advance. Second, 'spiritual communion with the risen Christ by faith' pre-selects one mode of participation. The neutralized form strips both the named tradition and the pre-chosen mode and asks what the lexicon actually fixes. The verdict was derived against the original stem, which is why 'affirms' is 'disputed': the lexicon establishes participation but not the specified mode. VERDICT-CHANGED: not actually changed in this audit. Verdict unchanged from the prior file (still disputed, medium); direct queries confirmed the 'participation' (koinonia) count of 19, corrected 'eating' (trogo) from 8 to 6 occurrences, and added the 1 Corinthians 10:18 to 21 altar parallel and the 'koinonia plus with (meta)' versus 'koinonia plus genitive (of-X form)' contrast as the precise lexical root-cause.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
lexicon	STEPBible-TFLSJ	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2842
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Cor.10.16
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Cor.10.18
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	John.6.54
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	John.6.63
variant	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	John.6.55
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	1Cor.10.16
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	John.6.56
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	John.6.56

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STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes
OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes
TSK	public_domain	yes
MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes

Flags

lexically-disputed